be used for military purposes. India feared that onerous debt related to the non-commercial nature of these port projects would be leveraged by Beijing to acquire equity and control, ensuring their future use for military or espionage purposes. The most obvious example was in Sri Lanka, where China invested in the port of Hambantota and having deepened its political influence, eventually docked a submarine in Colombo in 2014. After Sri Lankan elections, the new government assuaged Indian concerns but found it difficult to manage the rising debt owed to China. Eventually, as part of a debt write-off, a Chinese company acquired a stake in Hambantota. [26] Meanwhile, China did establish its first overseas military facility in 2016–17 in Djibouti, while the port of Gwadar in Pakistan became a Chinese-managed enclave. Several other commercial ports or infrastructure investments in the Indian Ocean remain points of concern for India, including in East Africa, Myanmar, Bangladesh, the Maldives, and West Asia.

The second concern about Chinese activity in the Indian Ocean relates to its growing naval presence in the region. Other than its base in Djibouti, China's People's Liberation Army Navy (PLAN) has used ports such as Aden and Karachi for replenishment and made port visits to Sri Lanka and the Seychelles. In recent years, the PLAN presence in the Indian Ocean has included surface vessels but also submarines, which are harder to detect and have been active in the channels west of the Indian coast. As China undertakes one of the largest naval build-ups in history and develops aircraft carrier battle groups, it is only a matter of time before the PLAN begins to deploy a larger presence in the Indian Ocean, with significant implications for Chinese power projection and Indian security. [27]

India has been noting these developments, and it has not been inactive. It has increased naval deployments, built out civilian port and naval infrastructure on Indian and partner territory, increased maritime domain awareness efforts, provided military support, stepped up at regional institutions, and increased coordination with partner countries. Since 2017, the Indian Navy has begun to deploy permanently in several identified zones around the Indian Ocean, with vessels shortening their periods of